08

PART 8 OF 9

The Early Church

ACTS 1–12 AND 15

From the Upper Room in Jerusalem to the council where the Church opened the door to all nations.



The Church Leaves Jerusalem

The Book of Acts tells of a dozen or so years in which a small community of disciples from one city became a movement reaching the shores of the entire Mediterranean. It all begins in Jerusalem, in the hills of Judea, a few steps from the Temple. Picture the crowd of pilgrims filling the narrow streets on a feast day, and a handful of people praying in the upper room of a house. That scene is the beginning of a story whose chapters lead through Samaria, the desert road to Gaza, Damascus, and the coastal cities, all the way to Antioch.

In Acts, geography is not a backdrop but a blueprint. The author, traditionally identified with Luke, arranges the narrative according to the promise in the first chapter: witness in Jerusalem, in all Judea and Samaria, and then to the ends of the earth. Each new circle is a different landscape: rocky hills, the fertile Plain of Sharon, Roman ports, the great Syrian trading hub. Distances were considerable, since it is about 220 km from Jerusalem to Damascus and over 500 km from Jerusalem to Antioch, so the journey took weeks on foot.

In this part you will explore twelve places where the Church learned to be a community: from the Upper Room and the Temple, through Philip on the road to Gaza and the conversion of Saul, to Cornelius's house in Caesarea and the gathering in Jerusalem that settled a difficult dispute. Four maps will show you the routes and distances, and artistic reconstructions, based on archaeological knowledge of the first century, will help you see the streets and houses of long ago. Read at an unhurried pace, with your Bible beside you, because each description points to a passage worth looking up for yourself.

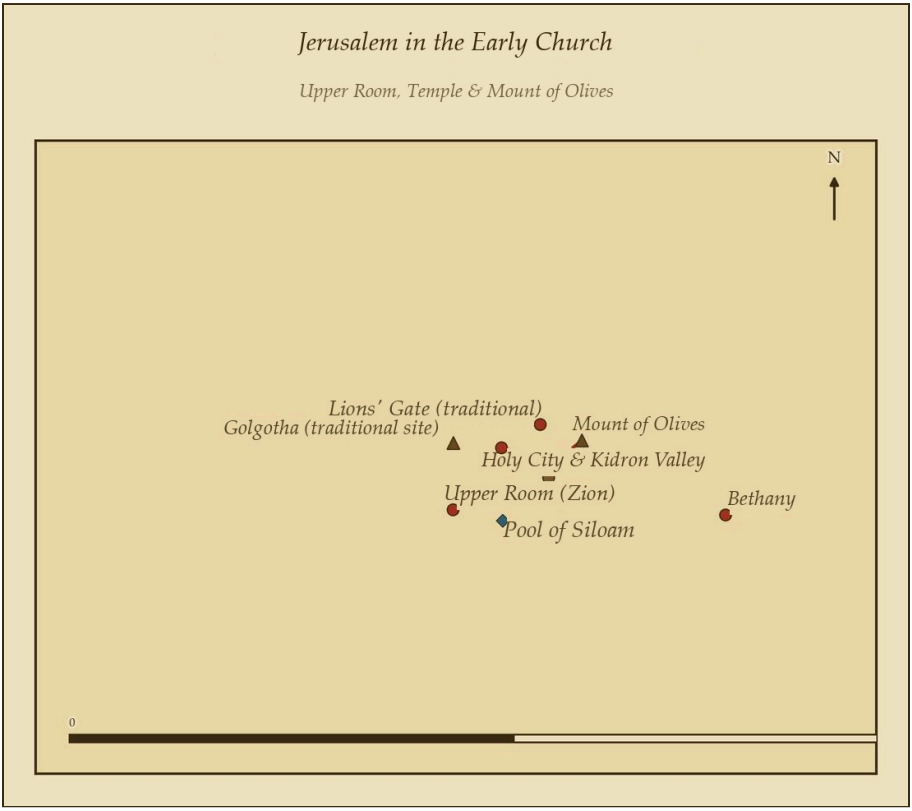
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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

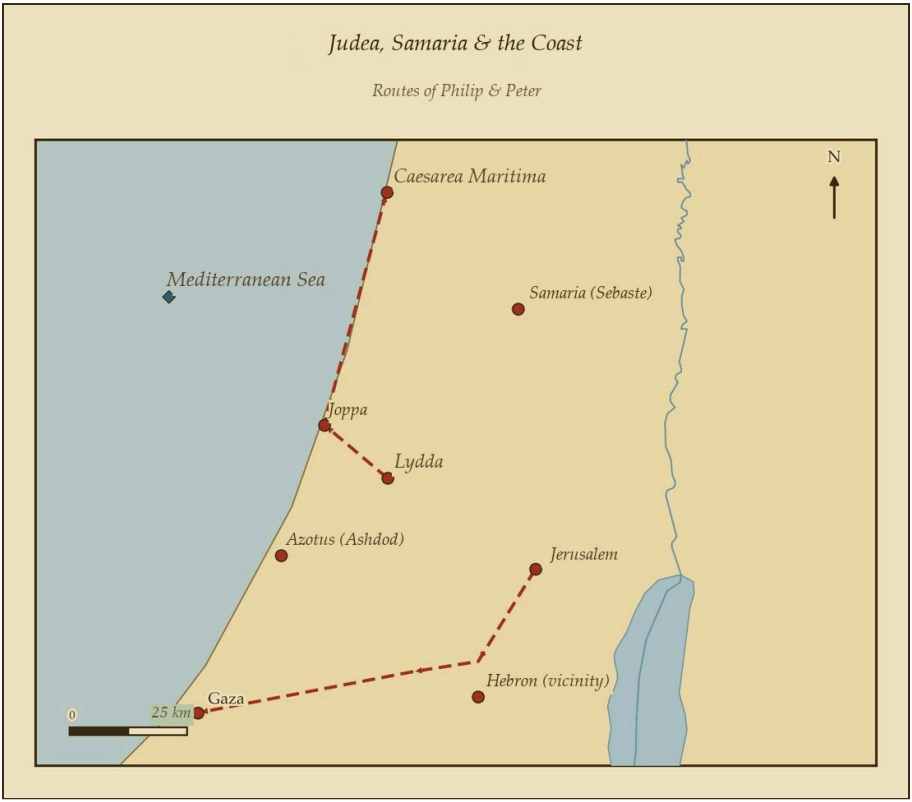
MAP 8.1



The map shows the center of ancient Jerusalem and its eastern approaches. The line marks the short route the disciples walked from the Mount of Olives to the city after the farewell.

All the events of the first chapters of Acts unfold in an area of just a few kilometers. The Upper Room on Zion, the Temple on the eastern hill, and the Mount of Olives, separated by the Kidron Valley, form the natural stage on which the community gathered. Notice how close together the places of prayer, teaching, and persecution lay, and why news spread here from one day to the next.

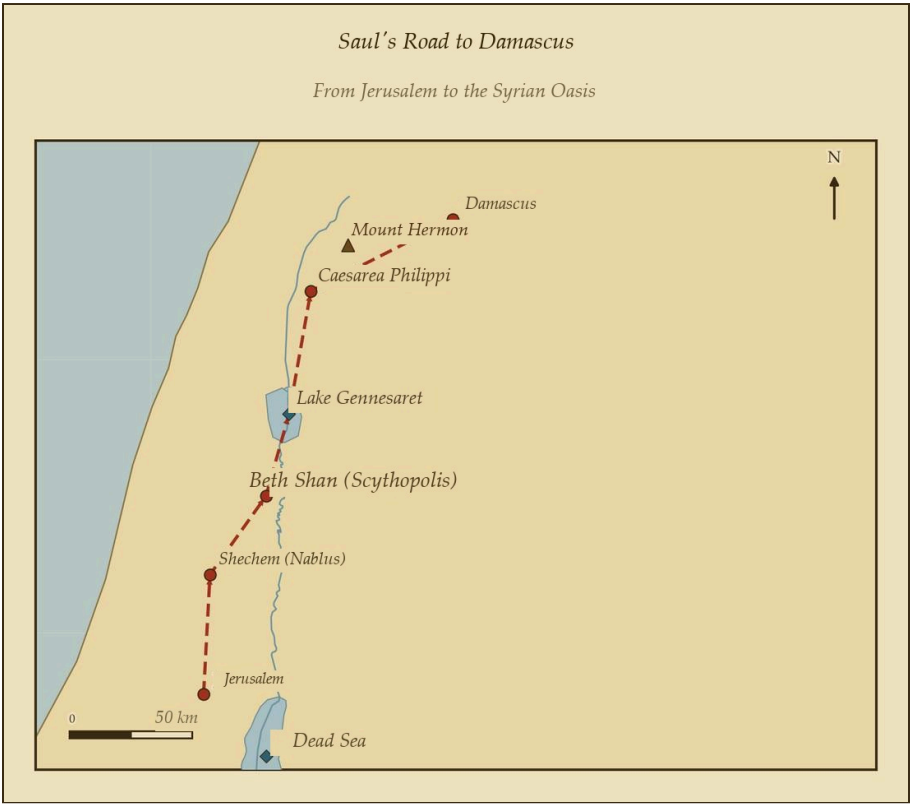
MAP 8.2



The dots mark cities and places in the countryside, and the sea is shown separately. The lines show Philip's route south and Peter's road along the coastal Plain of Sharon.

This map shows how the Gospel moves from the hill country of Judea toward the coast. Samaria lies to the north, Gaza far to the southwest, and Lydda, Joppa, and Caesarea form a line of cities along the Mediterranean. Note that most routes lead from the hills to the plain, and from the plain to the ports. That is why the word could travel on quickly from there, including by sea.

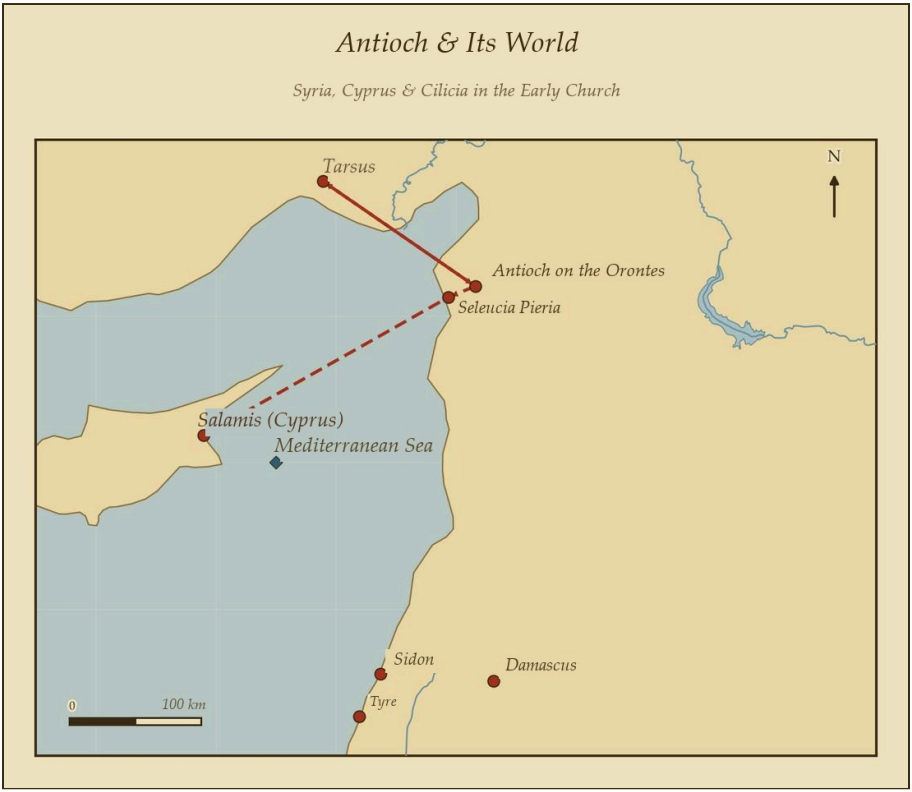
MAP 8.3



The map covers the road from Jerusalem north through Samaria and Galilee to Damascus. The line is approximate, because the exact course of the route is not given in the text.

Saul's road led from Jerusalem through the Jordan valleys and the region of Galilee toward Damascus, about 220 km as the crow flies. Along the way he passed the mountains of Hermon and the Sea of Galilee. Notice that Damascus lies outside the borders of Israel, so Saul set out abroad to persecute the disciples who had fled from Jerusalem. This is one proof of how quickly the faith spread beyond the country.

MAP 8.4



The map shows the northeastern Mediterranean with Antioch at its center. The first line is Barnabas's journey to find Saul, and the second is the beginning of the missionary journey.

Antioch was a hub from which roads radiated: to Tarsus in the northwest, to Seleucia on the coast and onward by sea to Cyprus. Phoenicia, with Tyre and Sidon, lay to the south, and Damascus to the southeast. Because of this, the city was in contact with both Jerusalem and the whole northern part of the Mediterranean basin. Such a location made it an ideal center for mission.

01 Mount of Olives – Place of Farewell

ACTS 1:1–14

From here the disciples watch Jesus depart and return to the city.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a gentle, stony slope covered with old olive trees, crossed by terraces and narrow paths. Below, beyond the Kidron Valley, rises the bright Temple complex with gleaming gilded elements, and in the background the compact buildings of Jerusalem. The air is dry, the light is that of morning, and the hills of Judea stretch into the distance. Pilgrims and shepherds with small flocks are tiny figures that give the place its everyday rhythm.

The Book of Acts opens with a brief reminder: for forty days Jesus appeared to the disciples and spoke to them about the kingdom of God. Then he told them that they would receive the Holy Spirit and become his witnesses. When he had said this, he was taken up, and a cloud hid him from their sight. Two men in white reminded them that they should not stand gazing into the sky. The apostles returned to the city, went up to the upper room, and, together with the women, Mary, and Jesus' brothers, devoted themselves to prayer.

The Mount of Olives is a limestone ridge east of Jerusalem, rising about 80–100 m above the Temple Mount and separated from it by the deep Kidron Valley. Luke says it is only a Sabbath day's walk from the city, about 1 km by the later Jewish measure. For the disciples this meant a short walk back along a path winding through olive groves. The view from the summit takes in the whole city with the Temple, which gives the scene a symbolic dimension: from here the message will set out to the world.

FACTS

Height of the summit of the Mount of Olives: about 810 m above sea level; about 0.6 km in a straight line to the Temple Mount.

02 The Upper Room – The Coming of the Holy Spirit

ACTS 1:13–2:47

In the upper room a community is born that sets out to reach people of every nation.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a simple stone house with a flat roof and an outside staircase leading to the upper room, shielded by wooden shutters. Inside are modest tables, low benches, and olive-oil lamps. In front of the house is a narrow, paved street where people in varied dress from distant lands are gathering. Morning light streams in through the window openings, and above the rooftops of Zion the city walls can be seen.

Fifty days after Passover, Jerusalem is once again filled with pilgrims, for the Feast of Weeks has come. The disciples are all together in one place when a sound like a violent wind is heard, and tongues as of fire appear over each of them. They begin to speak in different languages, and the foreigners gathered there understand the mighty works of God being proclaimed. Peter stands up with the Eleven and explains what is happening, appealing to the Scriptures. That day about three thousand people join them, and the community devotes itself to teaching, prayer, the breaking of bread, and mutual help.

Christian tradition links these events with the Upper Room on Mount Zion, in the southwestern part of ancient Jerusalem. The site itself is identified by tradition, and the present building dates from the Middle Ages. The hill lies about 750 m above sea level, a little over a kilometer from the Temple, so pilgrims could quickly gather around the apostles. The listeners named by Luke, from Parthians and Medes to Romans, show how far the roads to Jerusalem stretched: about 1,000 km from Mesopotamia, over 2,000 km from Rome.

FACTS

Distance from the Temple to Mount Zion: about 1 km; elevation: about 765 m above sea level (traditional location).


N
Upper Room: Coming of the Holy Spirit
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

03 The Temple – The Beautiful Gate

ACTS 3–4

Peter and John heal a begging man at the Temple gate.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

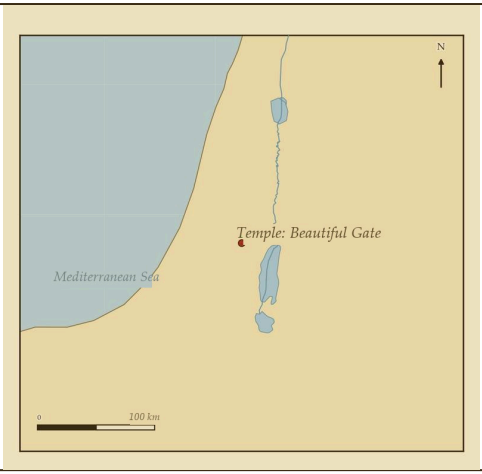
Artistic reconstruction: monumental colonnades of pale stone surround a vast plaza where pilgrims and priests pass by. At the entrance to the inner court stands an impressive gate with metal fittings, and by the wall sits the crouched figure of a beggar. Two figures in plain robes approach from the colonnade, seen from a distance or from behind. In the background rises the main building of the Temple, and the sky is clear, which emphasizes the vastness of the structure.

At the ninth hour, about three in the afternoon, Peter and John go up to the Temple to pray. At the gate called Beautiful, a man lame from birth was set down every day to ask for alms. Peter looks at him and says he has no silver or gold, but gives what he has: in the name of Jesus he tells him to stand up. The man rises, enters the Temple with them, and praises God. When the people gather, Peter explains that the healing is a sign of the power of Jesus, and calls them to repentance.

The Temple stood on a platform built by Herod the Great, covering about 14 hectares, surrounded by colonnades. The eastern side was occupied by Solomon's Portico, where the people ran together after the healing. The location of the Beautiful Gate is debated; it is usually identified as one of the gates leading from the Court of the Gentiles to the Court of the Women. Such closeness between a place of prayer and a place of begging shows how devotion, commerce, and poverty met within a single complex. The Sanhedrin met nearby, so the arrest of the apostles came quickly.

FACTS

Platform of the Herodian Temple: about 480 × 300 m; Solomon's Portico along the eastern wall was about 15 m high (estimate).


N
Temple: Beautiful Gate
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

04 Jerusalem – The Martyrdom of Stephen

ACTS 6–7; 12:1–19

The first martyr, and the persecution that scatters the community.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: the northern edge of ancient Jerusalem with a massive defensive wall and a gate flanked by towers. In front of the gate lies a stony road and open ground outside the walls, where a crowd gathers. The city buildings visible behind the wall are tightly packed, with flat roofs of pale stone. A gray dome of sky arches over everything, and a few fig and olive trees grow by the walls.

As the community grew, a dispute arose over the daily care of widows, so the apostles appointed seven men for this service. One of them was Stephen, full of faith and power. His teaching provoked opposition, he was accused before the Sanhedrin, and in a long speech he recalled the history of Israel. An enraged mob led him out of the city and stoned him, while a young man named Saul guarded the clothes of the executioners. A great persecution began, and the disciples were scattered throughout Judea and Samaria. Later chapters also tell of Peter's imprisonment during the reign of Herod Agrippa I.

Tradition places the stoning at the northern gate, today called the Lions' Gate, though the Damascus Gate was also once suggested. Both locations lie about 1 km from the Temple, on the edge of the city, where executions were carried out according to the law. The scattering of the disciples shows the role of roads: from Jerusalem, routes ran north to Samaria and Damascus, west to Lydda and Joppa, and south to Gaza. It was thanks to these routes that persecution paradoxically hastened the spread of the Gospel.

FACTS

The northern gates of Jerusalem lay about 1 km from the Temple; the city wall in this period had a circumference of about 4 km (estimate).

05 Samaria – Philip's Mission

ACTS 8:4–25

The Gospel crosses an old divide and reaches the Samaritans.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a monumental Hellenistic-Roman-style city built on a hill, with wide colonnaded streets, a temple at the summit, and a defensive wall. At the foot of the hill are terraces of vineyards and fig trees, and donkeys laden with goods plod along the road. The light is warm, and in the distance more ridges of the Ephraim hills loom.

The disciples scattered by the persecution preach the word wherever they have gone. Philip, one of the seven, goes down to a city in Samaria and proclaims the Messiah there. The crowds listen with one accord, for they see the healings and the casting out of unclean spirits, and great joy fills the city. Many are baptized, including Simon the Magician, who had earlier amazed people with his tricks. When the news reaches Jerusalem, Peter and John are sent, and they pray for the new believers to receive the Holy Spirit. Simon tries to buy this power and is rebuked.

Samaria lies in the central part of the Ephraim hills, north of Jerusalem, about 55 km by road. The former capital of the Northern Kingdom was rebuilt by Herod as Sebaste, with a large stadium and a temple of the emperor. Samaritans were despised by many Jews, so crossing this boundary was a deeply significant step. Fertile valleys ring the hills, and the route from Jerusalem to Galilee ran right through this region. That is why news spread quickly along the trade routes.

FACTS

Distance from Jerusalem to Samaria: about 55 km; elevation of the city hill: about 430 m above sea level.

06 The Road to Gaza – The Ethiopian Official

ACTS 8:26–40

On an empty road, Philip explains Isaiah's prophecy to a foreign official.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a long, stony road winding between light-brown, low hills covered with sparse grass and thorny shrubs. On the route stands a light two-wheeled chariot harnessed to a pair of horses, and beside it the figure of a traveler on foot. In the background a narrow stream appears with a touch of green. The sky is wide and faded, and in the distance the outline of the coastal plain can be seen.

The command is surprising: Philip is to leave lively Samaria and go south, on a desert road. There he meets a high official, the treasurer of the queen of Ethiopia, who was returning from a pilgrimage to Jerusalem and reading the prophet Isaiah aloud. Philip asks a simple question about understanding the text and is invited into the chariot. He tells of Jesus as the suffering Servant, and as the travelers pass some water, the official asks to be baptized. Then Philip is taken away and finds himself at Azotus, from where he travels on, preaching the Gospel all the way to Caesarea.

The road from Jerusalem to Gaza was about 90 km long and led through the hills of Judea, then through the dry, rolling Shephelah, toward the coastal plain. The exact place of the meeting is unknown, and tradition points to the area of Beth Zur or the Wadi el-Hesi valley. The description of the road as deserted fits the semi-arid character of the terrain. The encounter proves that the Good News reached far beyond Palestine: the Ethiopian kingdom lay hundreds of kilometers to the south, along the Nile.

FACTS

Distance Jerusalem–Gaza: about 90 km, or about 3–4 days on foot; a chariot could cover it faster.


N
Road to Gaza: the Ethiopian Official
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

07 Damascus – The Conversion of Saul

ACTS 9:1–25

The persecutor becomes an apostle and escapes through the wall in a basket.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a walled city in a green oasis, with a Roman colonnaded street cutting through the buildings, flat-roofed houses, and narrow alleys. In the distance, mountain peaks snow-capped in winter can be seen, along with a stony road along which a small caravan approaches. Over the city gate hangs a sharp afternoon glow, and the gardens along the Barada River contrast with the harsh desert beyond the oasis.

Saul of Tarsus, who had approved of Stephen's death, obtained letters from the high priest to the synagogues in Damascus in order to imprison the followers of Jesus. Outside the city a light from heaven surrounded him, and he heard a question asking why he was persecuting him. Blind, he was led into the city, where for three days he neither ate nor drank. Ananias, sent by the Lord, laid his hands on him, and Saul regained his sight and was baptized. He began to preach in the synagogues, until a plot forced the disciples to let him down by night in a basket through the wall.

Damascus lies in a fertile oasis at the foot of the Anti-Lebanon mountains, on the Barada River, about 220 km northeast of Jerusalem. It was an ancient trading hub linking Syria with Mesopotamia and Arabia, so a sizable Jewish community had its own synagogues there. The journey on foot took about 6–8 days. The narrow street called Straight, mentioned in the narrative, refers to the main Roman colonnaded road that ran from west to east through the city. The midday sun the text describes can be blinding here.

FACTS

Distance Jerusalem–Damascus: about 220 km as the crow flies, about 6–8 days on foot; the city lies at an elevation of about 700 m above sea level.


N
Damascus: Saul's Conversion
0
50 km

08 Lydda – The Healing of Aeneas

ACTS 9:32–35

On the Plain of Sharon, Peter heals a man paralyzed for eight years.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a large village or small town on a flat plain, with houses of mud brick and stone surrounded by orchards and grain fields. A narrow street leads to a marketplace where merchants lay out their goods. On the horizon the gentle hills of Judea can be seen, and the road is lined with rows of palms and sycamores. A clear day gives the scene a calm, rural character.

8.8 · LYDDA – THE HEALING OF AENEAS · ACTS 9:32–35

After a period of relative peace, the Church in Judea, Galilee, and Samaria grew, and Peter visited the communities. In Lydda he found Aeneas, who was paralyzed and had been bedridden for eight years. Peter declared that Jesus Christ was healing him, and told him to get up and make his bed. Aeneas rose immediately. The event made such a stir that all who lived in Lydda and Sharon turned to the Lord. This terse summary shows how a single event could move an entire region.

Lydda, as the Greeks called it, lay at a crossing of important roads, about 40 km northwest of Jerusalem and about 18 km from the port of Joppa. The main route from the coast to the capital ran through it, so news quickly reached many places. The Plain of Sharon, stretching along the coast between Joppa and Caesarea, was fertile and densely populated, though marshy in places. This combination of a strategic road and agricultural fertility explains why the Christian community could grow quickly here.

FACTS

Distance Lydda–Jerusalem: about 40 km; Lydda–Joppa: about 18 km.

09 Joppa – The House of Simon the Tanner

ACTS 9:36–43; 10:9–23

In the seaside port, Peter raises Tabitha and receives a vision on the rooftop.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a rocky promontory dropping toward the sea, and on it a compact town with flat roofs and narrow, steep streets. On the shore lie stretched hides and the wooden vats of a tannery, and wooden fishing boats rock in the small harbor. On one of the rooftops stands a figure in a plain tunic, gazing at the sky. The sun is high, and the sea gleams an intense blue.

In Joppa lived a disciple named Tabitha, in Greek Dorcas, known for her good deeds and charity. When she died, she was laid in an upper room, and the disciples sent for Peter from nearby Lydda. Peter, surrounded by weeping widows, left the room, knelt down and prayed, then turned to the dead woman and told her to get up. She opened her eyes and sat up, and the news spread throughout the town. Peter stayed there many days with Simon the tanner, and at midday he went up on the roof, where he heard a voice and saw a vessel containing clean and unclean animals.

Joppa was the only natural port of Judea on the Mediterranean, about 55 km west of Jerusalem in a straight line. The high rock on which the city stood made defense easier, but the harbor itself was small and difficult, with reefs at its entrance. A tanner worked with dead animals, which made him ritually unclean according to many Jews, so Simon's house stood by the seashore, away from the center. The choice of such a lodging foreshadows the breaking down of the boundaries between clean and unclean in the scenes that follow.

FACTS

Distance Joppa–Jerusalem: about 55 km as the crow flies (about 2 days on foot); Joppa–Lydda: about 18 km.


N
Joppa: Simon the Tanner's House
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

10 Caesarea Maritima – The House of Cornelius

ACTS 10:1–11:18

The first Gentile is welcomed into the Church without becoming a convert to Judaism.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: an elegant Roman-style port city with white buildings, wide streets, a semicircular theater facing the sea, and a long aqueduct on the horizon. Large merchant ships are moored in the harbor, and the quay is reinforced by a mighty breakwater. In the background stand stately houses with courtyards, surrounded by gardens. The light is bright, and the sea is slightly choppy.

Cornelius was a centurion of the cohort called the Italian, a devout man, generous to the poor. An angel told him to send for Peter at Joppa. The next day, while the messengers were still on their way, Peter had a vision on the roof and understood that he must not call unclean what God has cleansed. He entered the home of a Gentile, listened to his testimony, and told him about Jesus. While he was still speaking, the Holy Spirit fell on all who heard, and Peter ordered that they be baptized. After returning to Jerusalem, he still had to explain his conduct.

Caesarea Maritima was the capital of the Roman province of Judea, built by Herod the Great on the Mediterranean, about 55 km north of Joppa and about 100 km from Jerusalem. The city had an artificial harbor, Sebastos, a theater, a hippodrome, and an aqueduct, and Romans, Greeks, and Jews lived there. Cornelius represented the Roman military administration. Peter's visit to this cosmopolitan city marks a turning point: the Church ceases to be solely a Jewish community and begins to open itself to the Gentile world.

FACTS

Caesarea–Joppa: about 55 km; Caesarea–Jerusalem: about 100 km; the harbor of Sebastos covered about 100,000 m² (estimate).

11 Antioch on the Orontes – The Name “Christians”

ACTS 11:19–30; 13:1–3

The great city of Syria becomes the Church’s second center and missionary base.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a huge city spread out at the foot of Mount Silpius, cut by a long colonnaded street along which merchants, craftsmen, and sailors walk. Theaters, baths, and magnificent temples of white stone can be seen. The Orontes River flows through the city, spanned by stone bridges. The evening light gives the walls a warm, honey-colored tint.

8.11 · ANTIOCH ON THE ORONTES – THE NAME "CHRISTIANS" · ACTS 11:19–30; 13:1–3

Some of the scattered disciples from Cyprus and Cyrene reached Antioch and began to preach the Gospel to Greeks as well. Many believed, and the Church in Jerusalem sent Barnabas to Antioch. When he saw the grace of God, he rejoiced and encouraged everyone to remain faithful. Then he went to Tarsus, looked for Saul, and brought him to the city, where for a year they taught a large assembly. There the disciples were first called Christians. From Antioch relief was also sent to the hungry in Judea, and later the first missionary journey set out.

Antioch on the Orontes, today Antakya in Turkey, was the third-largest city of the Roman Empire after Rome and Alexandria. It lay about 500 km north of Jerusalem, near where the Orontes River meets the sea. The port of Seleucia Pieria was about 25 km away. The city was famous for its long colonnaded street, theaters, and temples, and had some 250,000–500,000 inhabitants (historians' estimates). Its diverse population and nearness to sea and land routes made it a natural center from which the new faith spread.

FACTS

Distance Antioch–Jerusalem: about 500 km as the crow flies; Antioch–Seleucia Pieria: about 25 km; Antioch–Tarsus: about 200 km.


N
Antioch on the Orontes: Where "Christians" Got Their Name
0
50 km

12 Jerusalem – The Council of the Apostles

ACTS 15:1–35

The first council decides whether Gentiles must keep the Law of Moses.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: the spacious interior of a house where community elders in plain cloaks sit on low benches. In the middle stands a speaker, with a scroll lying beside him. Light enters through narrow windows, illuminating the stone walls and simple lampstands. Outside, the hum of the street can be heard, while in the room there is concentration and attentive listening.

Men came to Antioch from Judea who taught that without circumcision no one could be saved. A lively dispute arose, so Paul and Barnabas, along with others, went up to Jerusalem. There the apostles and elders discussed the matter at length. Peter reminded them that God gave the Spirit to the Gentiles just as he did to the Jews, and Paul and Barnabas told of the signs among the nations. James, taking the floor, appealed to the prophets and proposed a solution. A letter with a few recommendations was written and sent to Antioch with Judas and Silas.

The council took place around AD 49, and the journey from Antioch to Jerusalem was about 500 km and took several weeks. Paul and Barnabas traveled through Phoenicia and Samaria, telling along the way of the conversions of Gentiles, which brought joy to the communities. Jerusalem was still the spiritual center, and the meeting shows that important decisions were made together, in dialogue, with reference to Scripture and experience. It is traditionally regarded as the model for later councils.

FACTS

Antioch–Jerusalem: about 500 km as the crow flies; the council is dated to about AD 49.

Questions for Reflection

1. What in the places described, from the Upper Room to Antioch, shows that the community of disciples gradually moved beyond its original setting, and what barriers did it have to overcome in doing so?

2. Why are Philip's journey to Gaza and the house of Cornelius in Caesarea such important moments in the growth of the Church, and what do they say about the role of the Holy Spirit?

3. According to Acts 15, how did the community resolve the dispute, and what from that way of talking together can you apply in your own community or family?